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SCAN TO SEE
THE WHOLE
ISSUE!

QUAKE RESPONSE

RESPOND TO RESPONSE.
City health personnel calms a hyperventilating student when the magnitude 7.6 earthquake struck Panabo City National High School during a school-based immunization activity on October 10, 2025.



School-based immunization turns into disaster relief

SHARIFAH CATE MAHINAY

PANABO CITY—A routine School-Based Immunization activity at Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) turned into a large-scale emergency response after a 7.6-magnitude earthquake struck during the activity last October 10, prompting immediate medical and disaster interventions.

CONTINUE TO PAGE 2...

Banana Capital faces declining plantations, DA calls for wider use of Trichoderma

Panabo City, long regarded as the Banana Capital of the Philippines, is confronting a growing challenge as Fusarium wilt threatens the future of its banana industry.

During an interview, Harold Moran, an agriculturist coming from the Department of Agriculture, stated that the said disease weakens banana plants by turning their leaves yellow and eventually causing plant death.

To combat and slow the spread of Fusarium, he introduced the use of Trichoderma, a beneficial microorganism applied to the soil.

“Before ka mag-apply ug Tricho, mag-apply ka una ug lime para ma-neutralize ang Ph (level), kumbaga dili na to pabor ang yuta sa Fusarium,” Moran said.

“Makiglumba na si Tricho kay Fusarium kung kinsa sa ilaha ang una makakuha sa space ug pagkaon,” he added.

According to Moran, while Trichoderma is highly effective, its application was said to be “trabahuso” and requires proper handling.

“Naa miy giadto nga farmer ug naa siyay area nga naigo sa Fusarium. Nag apply siyag ingon-ato (Trichoderma) ug iyang gipaningkamutan bisag hasol kaayo to nga approach, wala gyud nibalik ang Fusarium,” Moran stated. “Mao pud lagi, trabahuso kaayo siya ug naa ra jud sa farmer ug kugihan siya,” he added.

On the other hand, the agriculturist stressed that individual farmers suffered the most as many lacked access to timely information on disease control measures.

“Mailhan ra na sa individual farmer pag naay Fusarium kay nag yellow na pero kana nga time, daghan nag Fusarium sa punoan niya, nikatag na,” he stated. “Maong wala giapil ang Fusarium sa insurance kay ginaconsider na siyag sala sa farmer, dili siya natural nga host. Dili mulihok ang Fusarium, tao ray mudala ug magpakatag ana,” he added.”

Moran noted that the absence of technical guidance resulted in unhealthy plantations and forced some farmers to stop growing bananas.

Meanwhile, he said that farmers under cooperatives and large companies such as Tagum Agricultural Development Company (TADECO) experienced fewer losses due to early training and monitoring.

“Kay ako may nakakita sa data, naa sa 80-90% nga nangundang kay individual farmers,” the agriculturist said. “Tanan nga naa pa sa mga cooperatives sa Panabo, hangtod karon nagpadayon pa man kay naay klarong management as a group,” he added.

Further, Moran stated that equal access to information remains crucial in preserving Panabo City’s banana industry and sustaining its national standing.





PCNHS G11 seniors OK strengthened curriculum

PRINCESS FIONA TAO

A recent survey conducted among Senior High School students of Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) showed 100 percent approval of the strengthened Senior High School (SHS) curriculum, citing its effectiveness in developing critical thinking and practical skills aligned with students' chosen tracks.

According to the survey results, all participating Grade 11 students agreed that the enhanced curriculum helps integrate relevant, real-world skills necessary for academic and career readiness. Jhondelle Basmayor, a Grade 11 student of PCNHS, shared that the new curriculum is closely aligned with his strand and has significantly contributed to his personal and academic development.

"The new SHS curriculum really developed me in a way that is aligned with my strand. I am also glad that the government made efforts to help senior high students become more globally competitive and equipped with skills necessary for college," Basmayor said.

He further explained that the curriculum has helped him acquire practical knowledge applicable to everyday life, particularly in subjects such as General Mathematics, which he said teaches fundamental skills and concepts that can be easily applied in real-world situations.

Basmayor emphasized that the strengthened curriculum prepares students not only for college but also for daily life by reinforcing basic concepts that help ease the transition to higher education.

"I believe this new curriculum is paving the way for us to be prepared for college life. It does not only focus on college readiness but also ensures that students understand the basics, which can help reduce culture shock once they enter college," he added.

Although he admitted to not knowing all the details of the curriculum, Basmayor noted that its primary goal is to produce holistically developed, job-ready, and future-skilled graduates by making SHS students more focused, responsive, and prepared for real-world challenges.

Overall, the strengthened SHS curriculum received full approval from PCNHS Grade 11 students, who recognized its role in enhancing both critical and practical skills across different tracks, ultimately preparing them to be globally competitive and ready for college and life beyond school.

TMU response lags as PCNHS struggles with unauthorized parking, traffic

SHARIFAH CATE MAHINAY

To lighten the traffic congestion outside school premises, Panabo City National High School's (PCNHS) administration has formally requested the barangay office and the city Traffic Management Unit (TMU), urging immediate action to address the issue, however the latter has yet to respond with concrete measures, leaving the situation unresolved.

In an interview, the school's Prefect of Discipline, Sir Alfredo Kampag, highlighted that the problem stems from the unauthorized parking outside the school, blocking drop-off lanes and leaving little room for authorized school and public transportation vehicles to maneuver safely.

"Ang kana siya nga issue, gireport na siya sa school sa barangay officials og traffic management unit," he said.

However, Kampag noted that the TMU's current course of action has been limited to taking note of unauthorized parkers, though they have 'yet' to catch any in the act.

Furthermore, as a firsthand observer of the congestion, a PCNHS patrolman, Sir Ogie-Mar Montefolka, testified that the primary cause

of traffic is the overpopulation of tricycle drivers who park outside the school while waiting for passengers.

"Nakuhaan gyud na ug isa ka linya ang dalan diha, kay ang mga pedicab na, ang ka-lapdon ana nila, halos isa nana ka lane sa dalan," the guard said.

Montefolka further added that, as security guards, they have limited authority to address the issue, emphasizing that it falls under the jurisdiction of the barangay and the City TMU to manage those who are not following proper practices.

"If pahawaon nimo na sila, mangasuko mana sila," he highlighted.

On the other hand, Montefolka dispelled the common misconception that

students driving two-wheelers contribute to traffic, he clarified that as long as students park away from the main roads, they are not actually adding to the congestion.

"As long as wala nila gipatunga ilang motor, wala na siyay problema, kung tan-awon nimo ilang motor, naa raman sila dire sa gilid," he added.

Montefolka emphasized that the main source of traffic disruption outside the school was primarily the improper parked pedicabs.

As of now, the school is awaiting the TMU's intervention and effective measures to alleviate the persistent congestion outside its premises.

... School-based immunization turns into disaster relief

The immunization program, led by health personnel from the Department of Health (DOH), City Health Office (CHO), and Local Government Unit (LGU), was underway at around 9:30 a.m. when the earthquake occurred.

According to Nurse Moolien Jane A. Estimada, healthcare workers and school personnel swiftly shifted from immunization procedures to emergency response as students evacuated to safety.

"The nurses and staff managed concentration to maintain the pupils' composure and despite the stress caused by the earthquake. In one noteworthy instance, the healthcare providers acted quickly and stabilized the students in a matter of minutes after they started hyperventilating out of terror," she said.

Around 60 personnel from the DOH, CHO, Barangay Health Workers, Division, and School Health officers were already stationed for the immunization activity and immediately provided medical intervention and emotional support to students.

"The response was immediate. As soon as symptoms of hyperventilation appeared, nurses provided intervention and emotional support without delay, preventing the situation from escalating," Estimada said.

Furthermore, PCNHS Principal Manuel Esperanza, together with teachers, staff, the Emergency Response Team, and Red Cross Youth volunteers, coordinated evacuation and ensured student safety.

"I also wanted to note that PCNHS is equipped with knowledge and skills on how to handle disasters like the recent earthquake. The School Principal, Sir Manuel Esperanza, the teachers and staff, trained personnel, the Red Cross Youth and the Emergency Response team manage the situation effectively," the Nurse noted.

Estimada emphasized that the incident highlighted the importance of disaster readiness alongside public health initiatives.

She also expressed hope that everyone would recognize the importance of remaining calm and trusting trained professionals during emergencies.

PCNHS students protest tricycle fare overcharging

TATIANA SUMAMPONG

Tricycle drivers in Panabo City are under fire for allegedly charging students more than the mandated Php15 minimum fare, raising concerns from students about fairness, accessibility, and compliance with the Student Fare Discount Act (RA 11314).

Complaints have surfaced from Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) students who say that some drivers demand Php25 to Php30 instead of the legal minimum fare.

Marianne Ghaeyl Acdol, a Special Program of the Arts (SPA) student at PCNHS, expressed her frustration over what she called unfair practices.

"For me, unfair kaayo sila kasi normally student transport is Php15 and considered the standard minimum fare, pero maningil na sila ug Php25 or Php30 instead," she said.

"Dili tanan dako ug allowance, and many families struggle financially. The student discount may seem small, but it really helps students save," Acdol added.

Some drivers, however, believe that the minimum fare is insufficient

when students travel longer distances.

"Ang Php15 na minimum okay ra para sa mga studyante, pero natural lang nga mangayo og extra ang mga pedicab driver kung layo imong adtuhan kay mahal baya ang gasolina," explained tricycle driver, JR Bua.

Moreover, authorities from Panabo remind both students and drivers that RA No. 11314, or the "Student Fare Discount Act," requires public transport operators to provide the mandated discount.

They stressed that overcharging students is both illegal and unjust and that stricter enforcement is needed to protect commuters' rights and uphold fairness in public transportation.



PILLAR OF EXCELLENCE. Janelle Laquinta Fabian, a student of Panabo City National High School received the Daesang Award. BY: Yashen Cachuela

news bits

City Savings Bank backs school clinic renovation

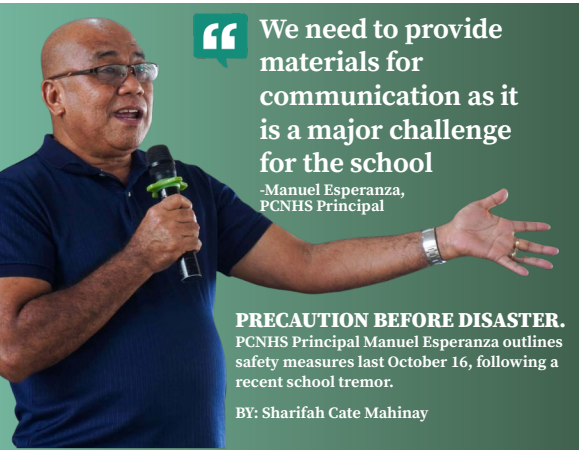
ELLAJOY ARICA

The City Savings Bank, Inc. has donated construction materials to Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) to renovate its school clinic, aiming to improve health services.

PCNHS bags award in PADAC mural painting contest

KHAELAH COMENDADOR

Panabo City National High School learners brought pride to the city after placing third runner-up in the Provincial Anti-Drug Abuse Council (PADAC) On-the-Spot Mural Painting Competition.



We need to provide materials for communication as it is a major challenge for the school

-Manuel Esperanza, PCNHS Principal

PRECAUTION BEFORE DISASTER. PCNHS Principal Manuel Esperanza outlines safety measures last October 16, following a recent school tremor.

BY: Sharifah Cate Mahinay

PCNHS eyes innovations to ensure school's safety

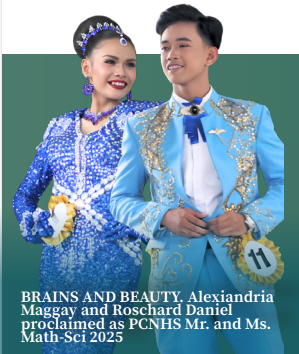
ALEXA QUIJANO

To address the sudden trembling felt in Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) last Friday, Manuel Esperanza, the school's principal, initiates training operations aimed to educate all coordinators on how to properly execute evacuation procedures during a mini press conference, October 16.

During the interview, Esperanza conveyed how the earthquake served as an eye-opener to flag the way people forget proper procedures when facing the said catastrophe.

"All teachers and students forgot the procedures of wearing hard hats because of the panic," he uttered. "We will be having innovations (and) continuous orientations on now to execute evacuation," he then added.

In line with that, Esperanza also expressed his relief upon knowing that 38 registered nurses were present of the moment the earthquake occurred because of the School-based Immunization program.



BRAINS AND BEAUTY. Alexiandra Maggay and Roschard Daniel proclaimed as PCNHS Mr. and Ms. Math-Sci 2025

Extreme heat poses ongoing risk to PCNHS students

CONSTANTINE CABILOGAN

During the occurrence of an earthquake at Panabo City National High School (PCNHS), several students collapsed after experiencing heat exhaustion while staying at the open grounds.

Students from the said school shared that this heat condition affected their everyday school experience and not just during that time.

Hanna Soliman, a Grade 9 student expressed that she felt uncomfortable and uneasy to move since she sweated easily, her skin felt sticky, realizing her lotion had not moisturized her skin because it dried up easily due to the warm and dry weather, which made her feel suffocated and strained.

"I felt uncomfortable because I sweat easily, and my skin felt sticky. We didn't really

have an electric fan, and the weather was really hot, so hot that it felt suffocating. Even when I put on lotion, my skin still feels dry," she said.

In addition, Janelle Pelpinosas, also from the same garde, said that while the heat is somewhat bearable, it often becomes so intense that even electric fans are no longer enough to cool her and her fellow classmates down.

"For me, the heat in our school is bearable. But that doesn't mean I'm fine with it," she stated.

"Sometimes it gets to the point where it's so hot that even electric where it's so hot that even electricfans aren't

sufficient enough," Pelpinosas added.

Meanwhile, Grade 9 Student Girile Tugnao suggested tolessen outdoor activities during peak heat hours. "For me, I really think that school should strengthen the implementation of limiting the outdoor activities specially during peak heat hours, and improve ventilation. By these, the school can more likely prevent the heat waves or reduce the heat waves rather," she stated.

With temperatures remaining high, PCNHS students continue to feel the effects of the heat during their daily classes and activities.

SSLG files strengthened waste segregation policy

NEMIE ZECH OBAGA

The Supreme Secondary Learner Government (SSLG) of Panabo City National High School has proposed a comprehensive garbage dumpster and solid waste management policy aimed at resolving long-standing waste segregation issues within the school campus.

The proposal, titled "A Resolution Strengthening the Implementation of Solid Waste Segregation in Panabo City National High School for School Year 2025–2026," was filed following observations of persistent trash-related concerns during the current school year.

SSLG President Sophia Romero Begonia in an interview said that the proposed project is expected to bring benefits to both students and the school as a whole, particularly in improving how the institution is perceived.

"Maka benefit sa students and image sa school pero the question is makatuon ba ang students o sadyang pugson lang jud nila ilahang sarili? Like self discipline rajud siya. (It will benefit the students and improve the school's image, but the question is whether the students will truly learn or if they will only force themselves to comply? It all comes down to self-discipline.)"

She added that the success of the initiative will ultimately depend on whether students develop genuine self-discipline rather than merely following rules due to enforcement.

In another interview, SSLG Adviser Harold Quitariano shared that the resolution was drafted after noting recurring problems in waste disposal during his first seven months in office.

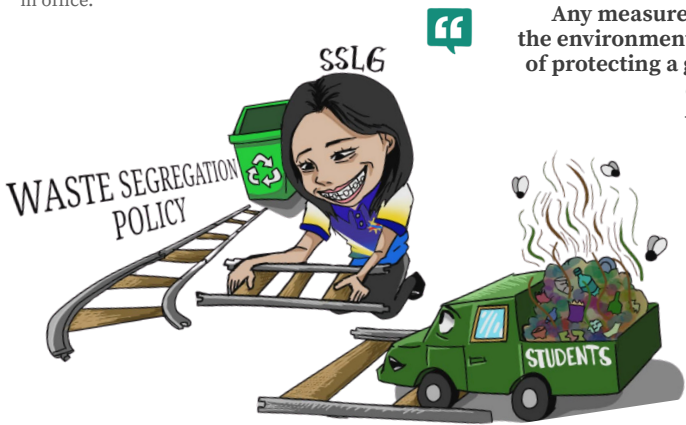
Quitoriono described the situation as a major concern that required immediate and systematic intervention.

"We realized there is a need to establish an implementing policy that will address the solid waste segregation problem of the school campus," Quitariano said.

Under the resolution, it includes requiring canteen owners to provide separate biodegradable and non-biodegradable bins and dispose of waste through LGU- designated points, strengthening coordination with barangay officials for regular garbage collection, restructuring the school's Materials Recovery Facility (MRF) with proper ventilation, providing segregated bins in all classrooms, enforcing existing sanctions, intensifying information campaigns, and conducting random waste management drills to promote proper waste segregation across the PCNHS campus.

While the proposal is still awaiting administrative approval, Quitariano expressed optimism about its long-term impact.

"If approved, we expect that this system will address the faulty waste segregation, reduce littering, and promote a clean and healthy campus. Any measure of protecting the environment is a measure of protecting a good learning environment," he emphasized.



Any measure of protecting the environment is a measure of protecting a good learning environment.

-Harold Quitariano
SSLG Adviser

G11 bets win 'PCNHS Mr. and Ms. Math-Sci 2025'

ALEXA QUIJANO

During the culmination of the 2025 Mathematics and Science Celebration, Grade 11 students Alexiandra Maggay and Roschard Ellister Daniel were proclaimed Mr. and Ms. Math-Sci 2025, proving their excellence beyond the academic scene.

Among the highlights of the program last Friday, September 26, was the search for Mr. and Ms. Math-Sci, which featured candidates from the different grade levels and special programs.

"Not at the moment, but if there's a need for a representative, I might step in as a last option, while participating is rewarding, it

can also be demanding, and I would like to give others the chance to shine as well," Daniel said when asked about the possibility of joining future pageants.

"Congratulations to the entirety of the sci-math events, this month was a success and I wish this prosperity to all the school's upcoming events," Maggay said in the same interview, extending her regards to the Science and Mathematics department.

Aside from winning the titles, both also received the Most Eloquent award, which was determined through their closed-door interview held on September 25.

editorial

BRINGING BACK TRUST

The Department of Health (DOH) and Department of Education (DepEd) recently launched Bakuna Eskwela, a program that brings free vaccines to schools across the country. This aims to protect students from diseases like measles, tetanus, and HPV.

Many students will benefit from this. But some parents are still scared because of what happened with Dengvaxia years ago. Dengvaxia was a vaccine for dengue, but after some children got sick, many people stopped trusting vaccines.

Because of that, fewer children have been getting their shots. This is a big problem. Vaccines help keep everyone safe.

When most people are vaccinated, it helps stop the spread of disease.

To fix this, DOH is working hard to give correct information. They are telling parents that the vaccines in Bakuna Eskwela are safe and have been used for many years. These vaccines are also given for free in public schools.

Teachers, health workers, and even some students are helping spread the word. They want everyone to know that getting vaccinated is the smart and safe thing to do.

The Dengvaxia issue made many families afraid. But now, we have a chance to build back trust. If more people understand how vaccines work, more students will be protected.



Ghosts I've Seen Before

KENNETH CARAMUGAN

I have heard this story before—big numbers, bold promises, and applause that echoes louder than the classrooms they are supposed to build. So when the Senate approved the Php 1.044-trillion DepEd budget for 2026, my first reaction wasn't celebration. It was memory. Memory of projects announced with fanfare, only to become footnotes, line items, or worse—ghosts that keep haunting the Filipino people.

I've seen these ghosts up close: classrooms listed as "completed" but never used; fans delivered only to teachers' offices; computers delivered without internet; training programs that ended the moment the photo ops did. Ghost projects don't just waste money—they steal time from students who don't get a second chance at Grade 3 literacy or senior high readiness. That is why this budget cannot afford to become just another headline. And we cannot afford to watch these projects haunt the Filipino people again.

To be clear, the size of the budget matters—but only if it can be followed, tracked, and felt. Php 1.044 trillion is meaningless if it disappears into reports no parent ever reads and buildings no child ever enters. By throwing its full support behind Secretary Sonny Angara, the Senate has placed its credibility on the line. This is no longer about intent; it's about delivery.

What gives me cautious hope is that the system, at least on paper, looks different this time. Multiple construction pathways—LGU partnerships, PPPs, CSOs, and direct DepEd-managed builds—make it harder for a project to vanish without a trace. Ghost projects thrive in silence and single chokepoints. The more eyes involved, the harder it is for nothing to pass as something. The same applies to teacher hiring, salaries, digital connectivity, and mental health support. I pay attention when government starts naming numbers and timelines—resolving teacher shortages by 2026, deploying 10,000 school counselor associates, connecting thousands of schools. Vague promises breed ghosts. Measurable targets make them nervous.

Still, I refuse to confuse hope with trust. A historic budget does not erase a historic problem. In fact, it raises the stakes. If ghost projects survive under a trillion-peso education budget, then the failure will be undeniable—and unforgivable.

So I see this Php 1.044 trillion not as a victory lap, but as a reckoning. I want to believe that this time, classrooms will be real, teachers will be present, and students will feel the change. But belief is no longer enough. This budget demands proof—and I, like many Filipinos, will be watching.



When academic prestige wrestles with pageantry in the classroom, learning suffers a fatal blow.



pausing point

Practice Makes Perfect

CHENZIE PACULANANG

A weary heart grieves the loss of free time, especially after tiring itself to prepare the school events to perfection; as if it was designed for the sole purpose of serving the school for achieving excellency and honor alone. Burdens breed in captivity of the body as your conscious self endlessly drowns in the drunkenness of the draining activities accomplished. All shown with a smile – a reality that many students face.

More than hundreds of student leaders in Panabo City National High School rot in their responsibility—binding them into the task they must fulfill; not out of money, but of urgency. Instead, exhaustion is expressed in club members enticing students to join their clubs as the school's Panagtapok 2025 wrapped up last October.

Roughly 8,000 students occupy the school, which is also led by around 18 excomms; deemed leaders of the diverse student body; with that alone, it is a generally acceptable truth that with great power comes great responsibility. However, this has not been the case for some, as power constantly wrestled with popularity that reeked in every classroom during election season.

In relation to this, student justice would always get somehow denied—with 9.5%. Student leaders had languishing mental health in the Philippines; this is an indication of burnout in students, despite teachers gently reminding them to enjoy life on their terms. The irony is not lost—it is shown as a harsh reality to the leaders who crave a single moment of peace that lingers their minds.

Despite school political tensions boiling as the events continue, it is undoubted that the Panagtapok 2025 came ensuing in success, given that this is a first for the school to host that event. Tiredness was rewarded in triumph, with each non-academic club standing at the pedestal; showcasing their advocacies with

passion and pride.

Being recognized as the Pillars of Excellence, it is also equally important to attend to the emotional and mental needs of a learner; not limited to performative excellence. A clear silver lining must be set between academic prestige and mental liability; with both playing a crucial role in honing the minds of these student leaders to remain steadfast amidst chaos.

Practice makes perfect indeed. In doing so, this would gratify a student leader's will to serve not limited to their position, but greatly extends for the people; only then would their hearts avoid stress, but instead abide to integrity, pride, and heart-felt dedication in serving the people.

The irony is not lost—it's shown as a harsh reality to the leaders who crave a single moment of peace that lingers their minds.



introspective

Enough, They Say

MICHELLE BRECIO

"Php 500 is enough for a decent Noche Buena."

That was the Department of Trade and Industry's (DTI) claim when it promoted the Php500 Noche Buena Project. While the intention may be to reassure Filipino families that Christmas remains within reach, the statement feels disconnected from the everyday realities of many households. For families struggling to get through ordinary days, being told that 500 is "enough" sounds less like help and more like a simplification of a much deeper problem.

realistic talk

Integrity Under Fire

REXHYN JOYCE GABISAN

Sometimes in school, everyone expects you to know every single thing. Teachers talk fast, homework piles up, and unexpected quizzes happen. When some begin to get overwhelmed, they start to consider the only form of tactic to pass: cheating. It is not that they enjoy the act of dishonesty but rather, they think it is the only way to stay afloat.

Many people say the act is understandable. Sports, chores, and homework collide, and school only keeps getting harder and the stress compounds into unbearable amounts. But when you really think about it, cheating is never a way of "helping yourself". It merely offers momentary relief at the cost of long-term damage. Learning is like climbing a staircase; to reach the top, one must take every step. There is no such thing as "taking the easy route", because by skipping a few steps on the staircase, one is bound to trip and fall. Later, you're blanking out on a test because the foundation was never built in the first place. Cheating won't save you, instead, it creates bigger gaps in your head.

For me, the real issue is that some schools treat learning like a competition rather than a journey of understanding. When you're constantly being compared to others, you start believing your worth is anchored on test scores. And when students think scoring low on a test equals personal failure, cheating becomes a tempting route to achieve good grades. But, it shouldn't be this way. School should be a space for growth, not a battleground where breaking the rules feels like the only way to keep up.

However, a strategy that cuts through honesty ends up cutting into your trust on yourself too. It creates uncertainty, starting to doubt if any achievement you get is actually real or not: dishonesty disguised as triumph. Honestly, I've experienced the act

too; feeling stressed and terrified of failing—knowing the guilt that follows. Most students don't cheat out of malice; they cheat out of fear. Most of the time, students tend to do this because they are stressed, tired, or scared of low scores, which is really a problem. If students felt safe admitting they're struggling, less would feel pushed toward dishonest choices.

This is where integrity comes in. Integrity is not just about following rules because teachers said so. But rather, it is about forming a character you can rely on even when no one is watching. An assurance that your work is yours, your progress is real, and your growth is genuine. When you choose honesty, you're choosing to trust yourself, to respect the effort you put in, and to build a foundation that will not crumble the moment life gets difficult. Integrity is not merely a school value; it's a life value. Ultimately, cheating should never be a tactic for survival. For that shouldn't be the goal of students—it should be learning. Real learning takes time, patience, and courage, asking us to face our weaknesses instead of hiding them. Perhaps the most important lesson schools should teach is this: success built honestly, no matter how imperfect, is always worth more than perfection earned through shortcuts.



If students felt safe admitting they're struggling, less would feel pushed toward dishonest choices.

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looking deeper

Comprehension Beyond Test Scores

KEZIAH GAMENG



Education should not measure how much students remember, but how well they can apply what they know.

In a system that values written test scores over hands-on performance, students are left with the perpetual belief that their intelligence is measurable by a single sheet of paper. They work tirelessly for hours without end, slumped over their desks both at school and at home, trying to get the numbers up. And if they fail, they walk home with that test in hand, believing that they are slow and unintelligent.

This reality exists not only in the Philippines, but on an international scale, for society has believed for centuries that a student's intelligence can be determined by a mere handful of tests, disregarding actual application in real-life situations. Yet, comprehension does not only apply to answering a 40-item pop quiz or memorizing a formula. True understanding reveals itself when a student applies and demonstrates skills in real-world scenarios.

Performance tasks: let it be projects, experiments, and similar activities, are not add-ons to education. They are not just something to squeeze in once the "real" lessons are over. Because for many students, these are the moments when learning

finally makes sense. It is where formulas stop being symbols on a page and start becoming tools. Tested, not memorized. Some students who struggle to pass written exams suddenly come alive when asked to build or explain something tangible. In those moments, intelligence is no longer about perfect recall, but about genuine understanding.

I once read a quote stating how you cannot determine the slope of a line given only one point, as there is no line to begin with. In the same way, a single quiz at the end of each lesson may point out the student's ability to memorize, but does not account for real application skills. Questions such as "How did you arrive at this answer?" or "How could

this be applied outside the classroom?" are often left unturned in traditional testing. If education is meant to prepare students for life beyond the classroom, then assessment must mirror life itself. Outside school, no one is handed a multiple-choice test before solving problems. Schools must balance written exams with tasks that value creativity, application, and real understanding. While traditional testing is crucial, it does not mean that performance tasks and application skills should be overlooked. If we truly want students who are ready for the real world, then we must start measuring learning the way life measures it. Not by perfect answers on paper, but by the ability to turn knowledge into true action.

hard hats, a habit born from years of living with national disasters, is perhaps the clearest reflection of our practical, no non-sense approach to risk. But is it really the preparedness of the people or is it because of the government's dilemma? Even conducting proper preparation and mitigation, infrastructures are far more powerful than us when we're covered. The power of an earthquake is far from predictable, mentioning that we are in the ring of fire, making sense that we are vulnerable to strong earthquakes compared to places with similar seismic exposure, like Japan and California.

No discussion of structural readiness in the Philippines can ignore the shadow of the Department of Public Works and Highways (DPWH) corruption conundrum. This issue creates a profound weakness in our national resilience. The most damning indictment is the government's failure to ensure the structural integrity of the very defenses meant to protect the public, a failure rooted in systemic corruption, particularly DPWH, which is responsible for constructing the country's most critical infrastructure, from roads and bridges to schools and flood control systems. Yet, the agency has been consistently plagued by allegations of systemic corruption, which means substandard and overpriced projects.

Yes, they are now exposed by the media, but what are we just doing? We did not take any action. The time for the debate is over. We are just wasting time observing their filthy works. The failure of our nation is not one of nature but of political will and moral integrity. For how long will we let corruption define the destiny of our nation?



grounded thoughts

Blame Game

GIELGEH POLLO



"The failure of our nation is not one of nature but of political will and moral integrity."



unfiltered

Free with Conditions

NEMIE ZECH OBAGA

Free healthcare sounds like a dream come true—especially for struggling Filipino families. But the zero-balance billing (ZBB) system, declared by President Ferdinand Marcos Jr., shows that dreams can sometimes get lost in translation. Designed to guarantee complimentary treatment for patients admitted to basic or ward accommodations in Department of Health (DOH)-recognized hospitals, the policy has yet to fully deliver on its promise.

Confusion still clouds public understanding. The policy is being oversold while implementation remains inconsistent. Even those who technically qualify for ZBB often face hidden or extra costs, undermining the promise of truly "free" care. Coverage is also limited to selected hospitals, leaving many facilities and patients outside the program. Announcements alone cannot measure the policy's success; consistent enforcement and genuine access are what matter most.

Coverage. By May 2024, 50.36 million Filipinos were registered members, including 37 million direct contributors and 13.36 million indirect contributors. Including dependents, roughly 87.22 million people enjoy some form of health coverage.

Non-registered patients can still seek assistance through hospital desks via the Point of Service program. Those unable to pay contributions are also supported as indirect members, funded by government sources



On paper, the policy is a boon—especially for the poor. In reality, free healthcare remains far from fully realized.

Hospitals have struggled to meet expectations. Patients are redirected, quietly charged, or left unsure of their rights. Paper guarantees cannot replace real access to care, particularly when policies are applied unevenly.

Officially, ZBB covers about 87 DOH hospitals nationwide—including five still under development—and four Government-Owned or Controlled Corporation (GOCC) facilities: the Philippine Heart Center, Lung Center, National Kidney Institute, and the Philippine Children's Medical Center. Not all public hospitals are on the DOH list, so patients must verify eligibility through the DOH or the Presidential Communications Office. PhilHealth provides the backbone of

such as sin taxes. DOH spokesperson Albert Domingo confirmed this in an interview with One PH.

Yet even qualified patients face the risk of hidden or additional costs. Funding still relies heavily on PhilHealth, with supplements from the Philippine Charity Sweepstakes Office (PCSO), the Philippine Amusement and Gaming Corporation (PAGCOR), and direct allocations to DOH hospitals. Zero-balance billing is a step toward universal healthcare—but the road ahead is long. Policies and paper guarantees are meaningless without consistent enforcement and equitable access for every Filipino. Until that happens, "free" healthcare may remain more promise than reality.

national outcomes. Learners struggle in an already challenged system, reflected in the Philippines' 77th ranking in the global PISA assessment. Awareness alone is insufficient—Filipinos must demand accountability to break this trifling trifecta of job mismatch, political complacency, and systemic inequality.

teachers are completely mismatched, 32% partially, and only 25% fully aligned with their qualifications. Governance suffers similar gaps, with some officials lacking the skills to lead effectively. These mismatches result from political choices that favor power over competence.

The effects show in student performance and

undermining public service. Teaching, once a noble and respected profession, is increasingly undervalued, often reduced to a tool of propaganda rather than a pillar of development. Many educators are placed in roles that do not match their training, limiting their impact on students.

Job mismatching is widespread: 43% of

Nationwide sectors including education, politics, and industry are facing a trifecta of crises that continue to push Filipinos toward economic and livelihood decline, as job mismatch rates steadily rise. This downfall is driven by systemic failures that limit opportunities.

Political complacency and corruption remains,



standpoint

Trifling Trifecta

CHENZEI PACULANANG

POTASSIUM POWERHOUSE

City that feeds the Global Lunchbox

ELGRAM MANLIQUEZ

Forget the postcards of white sand beaches; in Panabo City, the real "gold" grows on trees. Known as the undisputed Banana Capital of the Philippines, Panabo isn't just a quiet farming town but a high-energy city powered by a fruit most of us take for granted. Here, the humble banana is the heart of the community, turning a local crop into a global success story that defines the city's identity.

The landscape is covered by an almost endless sea of green. Panabo is home to one of the largest continuous banana plantations on the planet, with massive stretches of land covering 6,900 hectares which accounts for nearly 40% of the entire city. This isn't just a collection of small backyard plots; it is a giant, unbroken field that produces millions of boxes of high-quality bananas every year, making the local soil the economic lifeblood for the thousands of families who live there.

The reach of this city is felt way beyond the Philippines. When someone in Tokyo, Seoul, or Dubai peels a banana for breakfast, there's a very good chance it started its journey right here in Panabo. The city is the main engine of an export business worth over a lifetime, proving that what happens in these local fields matters to people all over the world.

This success isn't just about good soil; it's about smart farming. Panabo has moved far beyond old-fashioned ways. The city's growers now use drones

with cameras to check on the plants from the sky. These tools let them spot problems like pests or thirsty plants before they can damage the harvest, ensuring that only the best fruit makes it to supermarket shelves across the sea.

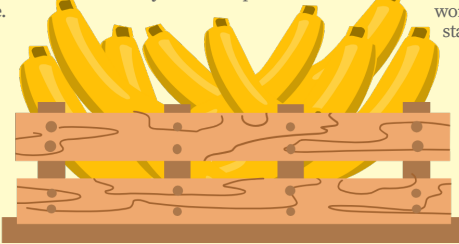
Efficiency is found in every hectare of the field. Many areas have set up smart watering systems that use sensors in the ground to check how dry the dirt is. This ensures that every single plant gets exactly the right amount of water and nutrients it needs to grow big and healthy. It's a smart way to farm that saves water while making sure the city remains a top producer year after year.

This agricultural pride is even celebrated in the city's culture.

Every year,

Panaboans gather for the "Binulig Festival," a thatorns the "bunches" of bananas that bring prosperity to the land. From street dancing to displays of the finest produce, the festival highlights how the industry isn't just a business, it's a way of life that brings the community together in a shared celebration of their hard work.

Ultimately, Panabo's identity is a mix of proud tradition and big dreams for the future. The banana industry provides jobs for a massive portion of the local workforce and helps the city grow faster every year. In Panabo, a banana is more than just a snack but the fuel for a city that found what it was good at, worked hard to master it, and successfully placed itself on the world stage.



QUAKES ARRIVE, RESOLVE ARISE

PCNHS Weaves Solutions Against Natural Crisis

ELGRAM MANLIQUEZ

Screams pierced the morning air and terror was etched into the faces of students as the ground beneath Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) began to heave. It was a moment where time seemed to stand still, yet everything moved at once. The campus was facing the terrifying reality of the seismic activity that gripped the region, following the massive magnitude 7.6 offshore earthquake reported by the Philippine Institute of Volcanology and Seismology (PHIVOLCS) on October 10, and the relentless aftershocks that continued to rattle the nerves of Panaboans through October 16, 2025.

hard hats, a habit born from years of living with national disasters, is perhaps the clearest reflection of our practical, no non-sense approach to risk. But is it really the preparedness of the people or is it because of the government's dilemma? Even conducting proper preparation and mitigation, infrastructures are far more powerful than us when we're covered. The power of an earthquake is far from predictable, mentioning that we are in the ring of fire, making sense that we are vulnerable to strong earthquakes compared to places with similar seismic exposure, like Japan and California.

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Classrooms may look ordinary, bland and maybe sometimes forgotten but to some echo a story of determination, a passion for change and a new dawn. Ian Reggy Paring, a Filipino scholar who studied in Japan returned to Panabo with a clear goal: to use his learnings and experiences into local impact.

Every structure rises on a solid foundation. For Ian, that foundation began in 2017, carrying the Philippines' banner by presenting research. That experience opened his eyes to the possibility of a higher education.

Soon, after he was sent into Nagoya University in Japan, Paring observed high school students programming robots, professors mentoring with precision and a community with disciplined citizens as a second nature.

His year in one of Asia's most prosperous countries ignited his passion to even brighter flames further desiring the improvement of his own homeland.

For Paring, it is more than technology or modern systems. It was about mindset, character and attitude. If the Philippines had the same goals, the same hunger for improvement, then the community would not fall in behind

More than degrees and riches, what he brings home is far more important than gold. Filipinos can stand shoulder to shoulder with the world if given the right opportunities. For him education isn't just a profession, it is a seed for growth.

"Work hard for your education; you are the next generation of stewards for our nation" He tells the students. Unlike speeches that fade after being spoken, Paring leaves a mark that stirs the spirit, creating a thirst for even greater heights.



TRIPLE B

Brilliance, Beauty, Beyond

JHONDELLE BASMAYOR

Between halls, she is a student. Beyond them, she reigns.

Who would have known that there is a queen, a crowned student who is walking elegantly inside the school premises? Who is this young queen and what journey led her to be honored as the first runner-up of Hiyas ng Binulig 2025? Embodying the Triple B creed—Brilliance, Beauty, and Brains—her story is one of hard work, persistence, and perseverance. More than a recognition, her crown represents a narrative of self-empowerment and dedicated advocacy, serving as both an inspiration and an echo for future young women destined to claim their own.

Sharifah Cate Mahinay, a name of elegance and poise, etched in the halls of Panabo City Multi-Purpose Tourism Cultural and Sports Center, as she strutted the stage with her outside the inspiring advocacy. What made her say “yes” and join in the pageant? According to her she came from a household of beauty queens, from the likes of her mother and aunt.

She was inspired to continue that legacy and that there was always a quiet expectation surrounding her, and people often looked at her as the next queen in the family. So saying “yes” felt natural and she began to take part in her mother and aunt’s journey in the pageant.

“My advocacy focuses on sustainable agriculture through Research and Development. As a researcher myself, I’ve seen countless innovative Science Investigatory Project proposals remain unfinished and unseen—simply because of a lack of funding”. Remarks of Sharifah and the truth beyond her advocacy, she’s not just a queen in sight but a researcher by heart. Her curiosity and passion for innovation led her to this very moment.

According to her, these unseen ideas could eventually uplift the community and standing on that stage meant representing those unheard innovations. These sentiments would certainly not just remain on the stage but be with her as she continues to voice her purpose and passion towards a sustainable future.

They say that getting the first runner-up in a pageantry was the most painful spot vaguely because of how good you are in the field but not enough to win, the same thought was also in Sharifah’s mind when she was called as the first runner-up, she said that for a second, the sting of “sayang” lingered. It wasn’t her night and the crown never made it to her head. Yet as days went by she learned to look at that night with gratitude instead of regret.

She realized that the experience didn’t define her worth, but refined it. Losing has taught her humility and grace, it taught her to separate her identity with her achievements, to see value in effort not in crowns. “And lowkey, niana ko sa akong sarili up kay lord nga ‘Lord, Binibining Panabo nalang puhon’”, she said.

But in reality, she was a winner, because not only she walked her passion and purpose but also won the hearts of intuitive people, she gracefully attained that title with the support of her classmates in Grade 12-Cassiopeia and her family. Sharifah didn’t just bring the title, but the hardships that she’d been carrying since this was her second time joining Hiyas ng Binulig was paid off. In her mind she thought of lacking in various aspects, but people will always see her as a girl who stood up and spoke for a change thus instilling in their minds that she is unique and is bound for another win.

‘Puhon’, or ‘Soon’ in English was Sharifah’s one word description of the whirlwind journey she experienced in hiyas ng binulig. “I think that the word puhon perfectly encapsulates my whole journey. From merely saying puhon to join, to saying puhon for the many opportunities and stages that await for me in the near future. Binibining Panabo? PUHON,” she added.

The story of Sharifah’s journey in the Hiyas ng Binulig 2025 was truly a story of how triple B she is, a girl with brilliance, not just for the glam and elegance but for the empathy that she has in upholding her passion and purpose to be a voice of the unheard innovations. Beauty, not just for her pretty and gorgeous appearance but in how she handles her balance with school works and pageantry life. And brains, for how eloquent and direct she was, delivering her answers without fear. She spoke on sustainable agriculture through research and development with one clear goal: to bring unheard innovations into everyone’s sight, for the hope of a better future.



“I think that the word puhon perfectly encapsulates my whole journey. From merely saying puhon to join, to saying puhon for the many opportunities and stages that await for me in the near future. Binibining Panabo? PUHON.

-Sharifah Mahinay,
Hiyas ng Binulig 1st Runner Up

PHOTO CREDIT: Panabo City
Information Office, Bryan
Guinto Photography



TREND YOU CANT EXHALE

Hidden cost beyond the vapor

MJ NARDO

The landscape is still shifting, and so is the way young people understand the thin line between attraction and consequence. Somewhere between the glow of popularity and the shadow of harm, a generation finds itself caught — pulled by what is trending, yet unaware of what it may cost.

Vaping was once introduced as an alternative for adults trying to quit smoking. Marketed as a safer solution for fully developed individuals, it was never meant for young hands. Yet today, it has become one of the fastest-growing trends among Filipino teenagers — colorful, discreet, and dangerously normalized.

“Everyone’s doing it.” It is the most common defense heard when students are asked about vaping. Across Philippine high schools, brightly colored e-cigarettes slip easily into backpacks and pockets. Some are disguised as highlighters, USB flash drives, or even candy — designed to blend seamlessly into a student’s daily life, unnoticed and unquestioned.

On the outside, vaping looks stylish. It appears modern, aesthetic, even “cool.” But beneath the sleek design lies a far different reality. Many teenagers believe vaping is safer than traditional cigarettes, yet what they inhale contains chemicals, including nicotine, that pose serious health risks — risks that often remain invisible at first.

To some users, vaping feels more refined than smoking a traditional “yosi”. It looks cleaner, smells sweeter, and feels less harmful. On social media, content creators perform vape tricks, promote flavored cartridges, and advertise so-called “nicotine-free” devices — many of which, upon testing, still contain nicotine. What looks harmless on a screen can quietly reshape habits, decisions, and health.

It is easy to get lost in the noise of online

influence. Trends move fast, and with them comes pressure. But a life is not meant to be shaped by what is popular today, especially when popularity comes with consequences tomorrow.

Alias Xander, a student from Panabo City National High School, shared in an interview, “I do not believe that vaping causes any significant damage to my lungs.” He added, “I have been using vape for four years, and I have not experienced any pain or health issues.”

His view reflects the mindset of many teenagers — young people who see vaping as either a safer alternative to cigarettes or simply a flavorful, stress-relieving habit. For them, personal experience outweighs scientific reports. “Four years without pain” feels more convincing than health warnings or long-term studies.

These misconceptions do more than blur facts — they shape behavior. When danger feels distant and invisible, habits form quietly. What begins as curiosity becomes routine, and what feels like freedom slowly tightens into dependence.

In the end, the question remains: is vaping an escape, or a confinement disguised as choice?

Because one day, the trend will fade. The devices will change. The flavors will disappear. But the lungs will remember. And by then, “everyone’s doing it” will no longer be an excuse — only a reminder that not every trend is worth following.



SIX SEVEN

Spoken too Sickeningly Often

ELGRAM MANLIQUEZ

It started quietly. Two digits jumping across comment sections, sneaking into captions, slipping into group chats. At first, it seemed harmless, but soon it was everywhere. Within days, it went from curiosity to a phenomenon, spreading faster than anyone could keep up with.

No one knew exactly where it came from and it didn’t matter. Screenshots multiplied, posts piled up, memes appeared. It showed up everywhere, typed in group chats, shared in posts, repeated by kids who didn’t even know what it meant. People didn’t need to understand it. They just said it, shared it, joined in. That was enough to make it grow.

Its power was in its simplicity. A number that asked nothing but grabbed attention, sparked curiosity, and made people laugh. Every post, every screenshot, every reaction kept

it moving, giving it life across timelines and platforms. It became unstoppable.

It wasn’t just a trend. It spread fast, reaching far beyond expectation. The number became a shared secret, a little badge of belonging, a cultural hiccup showing how quickly two digits could take over attention.

In the end, it wasn’t just numbers on a screen. It was energy, movement, connection. Two digits, big impact. One unforgettable pulse that left the internet buzzing.

TWO LIVES IN ONE SOUL

A ball spiking, a mike speaking

HILLARY FERNANDEZ

Balancing sports and studies is already demanding — but adding journalism into the mix creates a challenge only a few dare to take. Yet some individuals choose to carry both worlds on their shoulders: the fierce rhythm of the court and the quiet intensity of the newsroom. These are the students who dribble with purpose and write with passion, living two lives within one determined soul.

Being both an athlete and a journalist means discipline, grit, and stamina — mentally and physically. Long hours of training compete with long hours of drafting articles. Time meant for rest, recreation, or even social life is replaced with pressure from practices, deadlines, and expectations. After a grueling game, while sweat still clings to the skin, another match begins: the race against the ticking clock to finish an article.

Months of rigorous training sharpen not only physical skills but also emotional resilience. Athletes know the pain of repetition, the hunger to improve, the urge to keep pushing — the same values echoed in journalism. As sports legend Billie Jean King once said, “Champions keep playing until they get it right.” The quote fits both worlds perfectly. Both require persistence. Both demand sacrifice. And both are carried by passionate young individuals who refuse to give up.

The journey, however, is not without its rollercoasters. Some days feel overwhelming, as if the weight of both passions threatens to break the balance. Managing fatigue, expectations, and deadlines can drain even the most determined student. But with struggle comes growth. Every missed shot or rejected draft becomes a lesson. Every achievement — whether a medal won

or an article published — becomes a triumph worth celebrating.

Holding multiple passions teaches us more than skills. It teaches character. It molds resilience, sharpens time management, and strengthens leadership. It proves that passion, when nurtured with discipline and purpose, can open doors to new dreams. For student-athletes who also write, every experience in the court becomes a story; every victory or defeat becomes a message worth sharing.

Sports shape the body; journalism sharpens the mind. Together, they make a whole individual — confident, expressive, and driven. A student who lives in both worlds learns to listen, to

discover how one passion complements the other: the athlete sees stories others may miss, and the writer gains strength from the athlete’s mindset.

In the end, being both a student-athlete and a student-journalist is not just about juggling responsibilities. It is a testament to dedication, balance, and heart. It is proof that excellence can bloom in more than one field when fueled by passion. And it is a reminder that a young person who succeeds in both roles grows not only as an athlete and a writer — but as a well-rounded, responsible individual ready to face any challenge life may serve.





“Last G na, bai!”

A line known all too well by Filipino gamers. Yet, somehow, the last game becomes the past game and the next thing you know, the next match is already queued up. Gaming is usually framed as a method of coping, from academic stress and escapism, but when said escape is designed like a quicksand dragging you into an endless chain of immediate gratification through victories, achievements and rewards, it crosses the realm of escape into something much more sinister.

For students in the Philippines, the threat is real. A 2018 study of 300 Manila adolescents found that nearly 18% were classified as high-risk for online gaming addiction. That’s almost one in five teens whose daily routines, attention, and mental health are already being hijacked by the ever growing problems caused by gaming.

Though often mistaken for laziness or inattention, students’ difficulty in tackling school tasks go beyond simply being distracted. It is a product of short immediate rewards, and dopamine. Social validation plays a part in this effect as well, where logging in with friends, maintaining streaks, and raising ranks become a nightly obligation. Leading students to prioritize instant gratification beyond all else because gaming exploits the brain’s reward system in ways that school simply cannot.

Students who spend hours chasing ranks, completing streaks, and grinding daily quests often arrive at class mentally fatigued and drained of any ability to function properly. Assignments get postponed, study sessions are cut short, and comprehension drops. Research in the Philippines shows that students with high levels of gaming engagement report poorer academic attitudes and declining performance, showing that what starts as simply one game can cascade into missed deadlines, lower grades, and a weakened ability to retain information.

The academic toll deepens when gaming introduces stress and frustration. Ranked match losses, and competitive grind cycles create emotional highs and lows that leave students mentally drained, anxious, and less able to concentrate on schoolwork. Everyday exposure to these stressors interfere with memory consolidation, problem-solving, and focus making even small assignments feel overwhelming. Along with this, the sheer time consumption of games essentially cripples students’ time management surveys of Filipino students show many spend 3–5 hours daily on popular mobile games like Mobile Legends, hours that directly displace homework, revision, or study sessions.

Every single second spent chasing abstract achievements in the game fractures students’ minds piece by piece. Taking apart focus, sleep, and even motivation essential for their academic pursuit. If this cycle of disguised escapism and destructive obsession plaguing the minds of our young Filipino students is not halted by policymakers, parents, and educators, what price will we pay as a generation trades focus, grades, and sleep for “one last G?”

STUDY OF 300 ADOLESCENTS

1 of 5

TEENS SHOWING SIGNS OF ONLINE GAMING ADDICTION

18% AT HIGH RISK

SOURCE: 2018 STUDY

FIVE MORE MINUTES

Student sleep deprivation epidemic

KYLE DINOPOL

Research papers. Assignments. Quiz reviews. With the excessive workload students face on the daily basis, most are often left no choice but to sacrifice quality rest to comply with school requirements. According to the National Sleep Foundation, more than 70% of college students experience sleep deprivation, stating that they usually get less than 6 hours of sleep on average.

Without adequate sleep, the brain’s cognitive functions are impaired, with the National Institutes of Health (NIH) stating that sleep deprivation can cause a decline in brain function similar to being drunk – 0.08 blood alcohol level. A 25% decline in academic performance has also been attributed to lack of sleep, with the NIH finding that out of the college student body, less than 30% get the recommended amount of sleep– 8 to 10 hours.

Furthermore, lack of sleep has also been traced to negative psychological effects, with another report from the NIH finding that reduced quality rest does not supply the amygdala – the danger sensor of the brain – with enough impulses from the Medial Prefrontal Cortex (mPFC). This phenomenon leads to the amygladia going on overdrive, reacting to more stimuli usually progressing into anxiety.

Liquid sleep

To compensate for the lack of sleep, most students turn to energy drinks for its main component – caffeine. A survey by the NIH found that more than 50% of college students regularly consume energy drinks with 67% of them stating it was for inadequate sleep, with approximately 26% college students stating that they consume caffeine products almost daily.

Moreover, out of the 253 respondents, 29% experience caffeine crashing – when caffeine wears off and you end up more tired than you were – 22% reported having headaches, and 19% having palpitations weekly. Knowing the health risks of caffeine products, these people are often left no choice but to consume them to keep up with their expanding work toll as students.

Caffeine products work by blocking the adenosine hormone – a neurotransmitter responsible for sleepiness, leading to alertness. While it can temporarily reduce fatigue, energy drinks can overstimulate the brain, leading to insomnia, anxiety, and even in some cases, addiction.

SLEEP DEPRIVATION IMPAIRS BRAIN FUNCTION EQUAL TO A

0.08

BLOOD ALCOHOL LEVEL

STUDENTS AVERAGE

Less than

6 HOURS OF SLEEP

OVER 50% OF STUDENTS RELY ON ENERGY DRINKS TO COPE WITH SLEEP LOSS

ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE DROPS BY

25%

DUE TO LACK OF SLEEP

LEARNING AND MEMORY CAN DECLINE BY UP TO

40%

WITHOUT ADEQUATE SLEEP



To BACK OFF TOBACCO

Inside the mind, student smokers

8 million a year, cigarettes. The tobacco epidemic still reigns over youth today, with 1.3 billion active smokers in low-middle class societies. What's worse is that out of the 8 million casualties annually caused by tobacco-related products, an estimated amount of over 1.3 million of them are non-smokers who developed respiratory complications from second-hand exposure to the substance.

According to a 22-year global study from The Tobacco Atlas, more than 30% of the recorded 1.3 billion active smokers were initiated into the practice when they were still 15-16 years old. Furthermore, a report from the National Institutes of Health states that 75% of teens who were exposed to tobacco and nicotine from a young age became active smokers as adults.

With how tobacco products are, it’s hard to understand from an outside perspective why people like consuming it. Cigarettes are often used as depressants due to its main component, nicotine. A substance that affects the limbing system – the section of the brain that houses the sense of pleasure – releasing dopamine and creating a euphoric effect that lasts for less than 2 hours.

Depressant to depressant

Despite being a known calmative, overexposure to smoking can actually lead to negative long-term effects regarding mental health. According to Action on Smoking and Health(ASH), smoking has been associated with increased risk of major depression due to the dopamine release that nicotine encompasses. When dopamine is released superficially due to exposure to things like smoking, the brain gets accustomed to the high levels of the hormone and thus demands for higher levels of it.

This phenomenon is the main reason as to why cigarettes are so addictive, numbing the brain to what should be the normal level of dopamine, demanding more mediums that supply the same amount of high –cigarettes. So, when the user decides to quit smoking, one of two things generally happen, they experience anxiety, increased irritability, weight gain, and other common withdrawal symptoms or they just go back to smoking. While help is abundantly available for these users, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention(CDC) states that the successful rehabilitation rate for nicotine addicts is less than 10%. Throughout the years, the cigarette industry themselves have tried to help with the cause, putting cautionary warnings on their products to spread awareness of the detrimental health complications that their products could incur.

Better, but still not good

As of recent years an alternative for cigarettes has been made and has been marketed as the healthier option for active smokers. Electronic Nicotine Delivery Systems (ENDS) like vapes and e-cigarettes have the same effect as traditional tobacco but has a lower chemical content – traditional tobacco products exude 7,000 chemicals when combusted while ENDS have 2,000 chemicals.

While they are healthier than traditional tobacco cigarettes, over 800 different studies say that they still pose a significant health risk. Containing aldehydes --a chemical compound that can cause lung and cardiovascular disease--and benzene, a compound usually found in car exhaust and metals like nickel, tin, and lead.

ASH Executive Director Dr. study in the Journal of Affective Disorders with more than 3,000 adolescents. They found that TikTok use disorder was linked with weaker memory performance, and stress and mood seemed to explain part of that decline. It’s not one single dramatic effect, more like small shifts that add up. Some psychologists think the app’s design is a big part of why these patterns show up. Cognitive-load theory has been around for a long time, and it basically says that when you’re taking in a lot of information very quickly, your working memory gets overwhelmed. TikTok’s pace, plus the nonstop personalization, creates the kind of environment where that’s pretty likely to happen. After a while, slower tasks like reading or writing feel heavier than they should, which a lot of students already complain about.

When you put all the studies together, a pretty steady picture forms. TikTok doesn’t harm everyone equally, and some people seem fine with it, but there’s consistent evidence linking heavy use with shorter attention spans, shakier memory, and more emotional strain. Knowing this doesn’t mean you have to delete the app; it just gives you a clearer sense of what might be happening in the background and helps you decide how you want to use it.



Maria Encarnita Limpin stated “For us health care providers, we always apply the precautionary principle, meaning we must exercise caution until safety is proven for any potential disease-causing agent. That’s why you’ll never hear us recommend the use of electronic cigarettes.”

Generational Low

The demand for cigarettes fell by 51% from 53.6 packs in 2010 to 26.3 packs per person worldwide. A CDC survey of U.S. high school and middle school found that the main factor of the drastic decline in demand for cigarettes is the emergence of ENDS. According to CDC senior adviser Kristy Marynak, that they’re working restlessly due to the predatory marketing of the tobacco industry.

Furthermore, the rate of youth smokers has decreased significantly as of recent years, from 36.4% in the late 90s to 9.8% in 2015. Despite the abysmal rate of rehabilitation regarding tobacco and nicotine addictions, countless organizations are working to flatten the curve with evident results, with recorded rates of youth smokers going down by 7% in the span of 2022 to 2023.

All-in-all, while the prominent issue of student smokers still remains a relevancy, strides to address the problem has been evident. With organizations and initiatives from both government and non-government institutes advocating awareness for the cause, the complete isolation from the tobacco epidemic should be within arms reach.

SOURCE: 22-YEAR GLOBAL STUDY FROM THE TOBACCO ATLAS

30% of 1.3 billion active smokers were initiated into the practice when they were 15-16 years old.

ACCORDING TO NATIONAL INSTITUTES OF HEALTH...

75% of teens exposed to tobacco, nicotine from a young age became active smokers as adults.

PRESCRIBED: EDUCATION

JHONDELLE BASMAYOR

HIV, the disease that plunged humanity into chaos. Yes, you heard that right—the virus that fuels stigma and sows confusion among the unaware. But if this virus is scaring us, why not learn about it?

HIV is caused by the Human Immunodeficiency Virus, which attacks the body’s immune system, specifically the CD4 (T-helper) cells. This weakens the body’s defense against infections and diseases. The virus is said to have originated in Central Africa, specifically from chimpanzees (Pan troglodytes troglodytes) in southeastern Cameroon. Scientists found that these chimpanzees carried SIVcpz (Simian Immunodeficiency Virus), which is almost genetically identical to HIV-1. When humans were exposed to infected chimpanzee blood—most likely through bushmeat hunting and butchering—the virus crossed over into people.

And this can be transferred from mother to child, through unprotected sex, sharing needles or syringes, and blood transfusion or organ transplant from an HIV-positive donor. HIV often starts with flu-like symptoms such as fever, rash, sore throat, and swollen lymph nodes, though some show no signs. It can stay hidden for years while weakening the immune system. If untreated, it may progress to AIDS, or Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome, causing severe weight loss, infections, and extreme fatigue. The only sure way to confirm HIV is through testing, as symptoms can resemble other illnesses.

Dr. Anthony Fauci, the Director of the U.S. National Institute of Allergy and Infectious Diseases (NIAID), has emphasized, “HIV is not a disease of any one group. It is a virus that can infect anyone exposed to it,” highlighting the stigma that HIV only infects “gay men,” which is not true but only a myth. HIV is not a punishment, nor is it a disease limited to one community; it is a virus that can affect anyone. What makes it more dangerous than the infection itself is the stigma and ignorance that surround it. Instead of pushing people away out of fear, we must replace judgment with knowledge, discrimination with compassion, and fear with awareness. Because in the end, the real fight against HIV is not just medical—it is also social, and it begins with understanding.

“Education, awareness, and prevention are the key, but stigmatization and exclusion from family are what make people suffer most.” —Ralph Fiennes



FALLING ON DEAF EARS

The hearing loss epidemic

KYLE DINOPOL

“Huh”? A word said more than greetings. Not just old men or women, but even over 34 million children worldwide. Everybody is going deaf.

According to a recent study by the World Health Organization (WHO), over 1.5 billion people are suffering from some degree of hearing loss, with most of those at risk of permanent hearing loss not even being over the age of 35. While it is important to note that such future is still avoidable, several systematic factors erect difficulties in doing so.

One of the largest factors in the difficulty of facing this problem is perception. People tend to assume that hearing loss is exclusively natural—a problem everybody is going to inevitably face—when in fact, over 50% of diagnosed losses were completely preventable. According to the WHO, surveys show that over 60% of adults believe hearing loss is an inevitable part of aging, and nearly half of younger respondents (under 40) also assume it cannot be prevented.

Another difficulty is that the main cause of this generationally progressive epidemic has not only been normalized, but celebrated. In the late 2010s, with the rise of wireless headphones and the trademark “headphone look,” young adults embraced unsafe listening practices as part of modern culture. A few years later, the WHO reported that over 20% of young teens aged 12–19 already show signs of premature hearing loss. The warnings were clear, but ironically, the people were not listening.

The human ear is biologically designed to handle sounds around 60–70 decibels without sustaining significant damage. Yet, modern listening practices often expose ears to volumes as high as 105 decibels through headphones and earbuds. It is crucial to understand that the decibel scale is logarithmic: every increase of 10 dB represents a tenfold increase in sound intensity. This means that listening at 105 dB is not just “35 points higher” than safe levels—it is thousands of times more intense than what the ear can safely tolerate.

However, this does not have to be you. Modern electronic devices recognize the hazard that such high levels of sound could be, and consequently would warn you—all you have to do, is listen. Governments, too, are stepping forward: the World Health Organization has urged nations to adopt national hearing care strategies, and evidence shows that every dollar invested in hearing health returns sixteen in economic and social benefits. The tools exist, the science is clear—what remains is the collective will to act.

With billions of ears at stake, it all suddenly seems so ironic. That the only thing humanity needs to do to get away from the hearing loss epidemic, is to listen.

“That the only thing humanity needs to do to get away from the hearing loss epidemic, is to listen.”



Students unveil a new step towards accessible renewable energy

KYLE DINOPOL

164.25 million tons a year, enough to cover the circumference of the earth not only once, but nearly three times over. Night soil is a term from the olden days referring to human excrement collected from buckets, outhouses, cesspools, and septic tanks. It is an extremely abundant material that has found hardly any other use except for agriculture – and even that is fading into obscurity.

According to a report from the World Health Organization (WHO) in 2019, 432,000 annual deaths came as a result of improper sanitation and disposal of human waste, stemming from diseases like pneumonia, meningitis, and diarrhea. This is why the use of night soil as a fertilizer has recently been met with large resistance, as it leaves the produce consumers vulnerable to enteric microorganisms and parasites like *E. coli*.

With little to no implications besides agriculture, night soil is becoming more and more of an issue as time goes by, contributing to 5–30% of organic waste production in the Eastern regions of the Earth. The worst part is that people can't even dispose of it like common landfill, as it could have detrimental impact to climate change from methane emission—a greenhouse gas 28 times more impactful than carbon dioxide.

Output to input

A recent study from Panabo City National High School (PCNHS) found that night soil could actually be the next integral material for sustainable and renewable energy. Through anaerobic

digesters—systems that allow microorganisms to break down organic material with the absence of oxygen—night soil could consistently produce biogas, a type of renewable resource akin to natural gas usually extracted from organic waste material.

Researchers Rhona Jessica T. Bernardino, Shahanah Jame A. Poliquit, and Klient Josh P. Tiempo found that while food waste could also be refined into biogas, the higher moisture content of night soil directly contributed to more yields, with 11.636 mL for every 25 kilograms of food waste and 2.3227 mL for natural soil. The moisture levels of the substrate matter because it promotes microbial activity, as bacteria population is denser in moisture-rich areas.

While the project is a small-scale representation of biogas production through organic material—only going through a 22-day observation with its highest yield at 5.5 mL of biogas—it shows the potency of night soil as a renewable energy resource. Additionally, the revelation also poses as a solution to improper handling of organic waste, opening a gateway for people to make use of the environmentally harmful

and abundant resource which is night soil.

Diamond in the excrement

The research paper was an entry for the School Science and Technology Fair 2024, presenting the potential value of night soil besides the agricultural implications of it as a fertilizer. While the study only showed a small-scale model of the biogas generator, the students showed the latent consistency in yields and potency as a renewable energy resource that night soil had.

If this innovation were to be met with further development, the reliance of fossil fuels and non-renewable energy resources could be significantly relieved, not only in the Philippines but for the whole world. With yearly greenhouse gas emissions at an all-time high—37.4 billion tons of carbon dioxide; methane emissions 26 times higher than in the 60s—the need for a better energy source is needed now more than ever.

Who would have thought that the next renewable resource would be found in septic tanks even more so that it would be students that found it.

FINDING NEMO:THE FISHY HOME CRISIS

KYLE DINOPOL

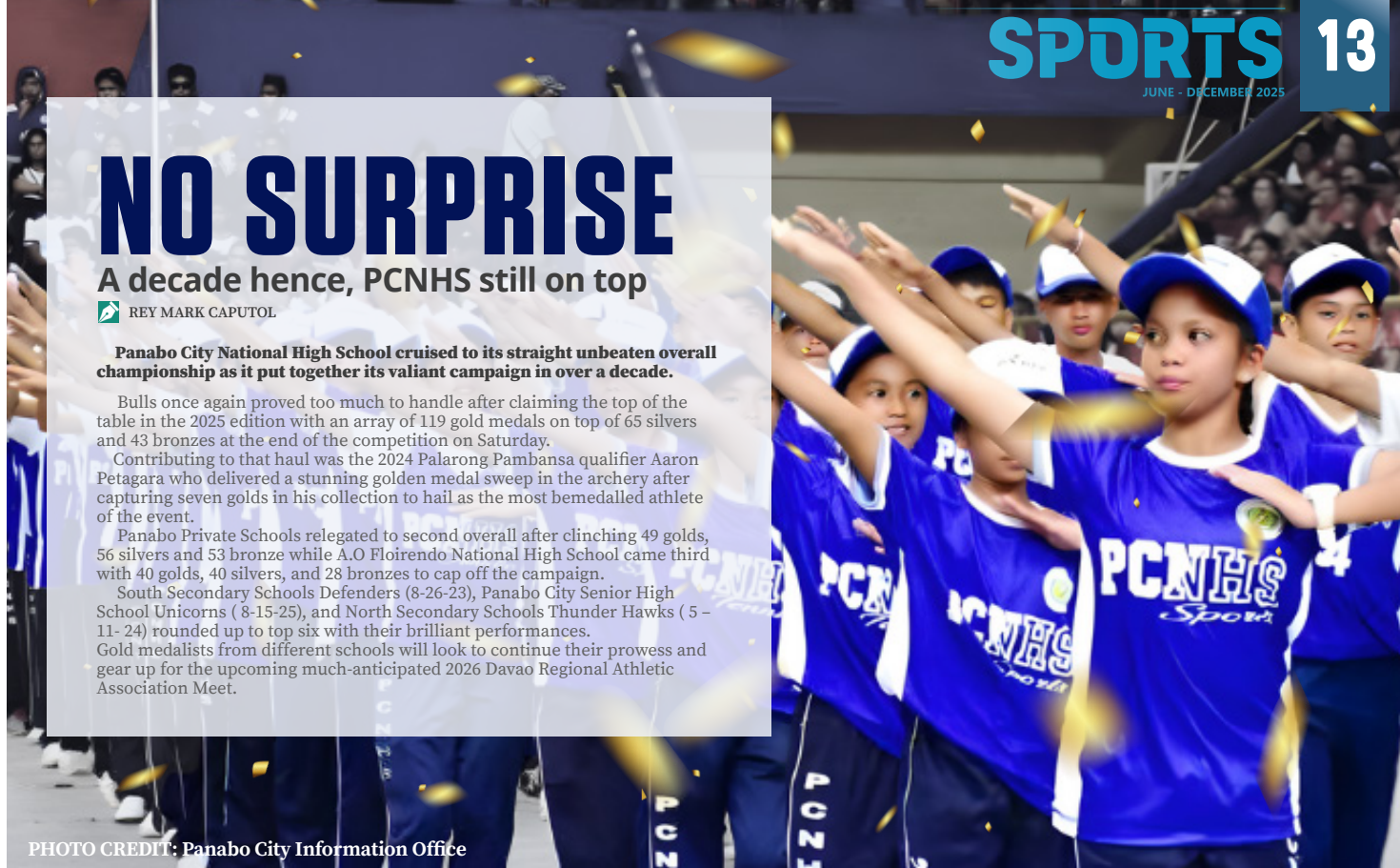
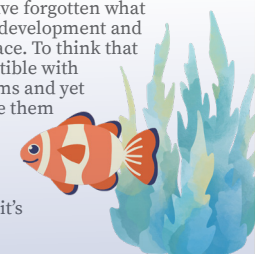
44%. Nearly half of all warm water corals are now in range of extinction. At the current rate, nearly all marine life on Earth will lose their food, foraging grounds, and hiding place—they will lose their homes. And yet, its silent killers show no sign of stopping.

Climate change, ocean acidification, and human influence are the leading causes for this crisis—in fact, they already account for nearly half of all coral species being threatened, double-digit reef loss in just one decade, and a near-total collapse projected if warming exceeds 2°C. According to the International Union for Conservation of Nature, in the span of 11 years from 2008-2019, 14% of the world's coral reef were faced with immediate threats of extinction—to put into perspective, that's roughly 11,700 square kilometers, an area larger than the entire country of Haiti.

What the masses see as booming markets and innovations in various global sectors are actually one of the main causes of this silent collapse. The demand for energy to power industries, data centers, and global trade continues to rise, and with it, carbon emissions pour into the atmosphere. Every ton of CO₂ absorbed by the ocean pushes reefs closer to collapse—weakening their skeletons, bleaching their colors, and stripping away the homes of millions of marine species.

Coral reefs act as natural wave barriers, absorbing up to 97% of the energy generated by waves. Their collapse would not only devastate the livelihoods of coastal communities that depend on fishing as a primary source of income, but also strip away a critical line of defense against typhoons, storms, and surges. Without reefs, millions living along vulnerable coastlines would face heightened risks of flooding, erosion, and disaster.

The irony is staring you in the eyes at this point. In the pursuit of global and rapid innovation, humanity seems to have forgotten what had to adapt for their development and survival in the first place. To think that humans are so compatible with nature's vast ecosystems and yet so willing to dismantle them for short-term gain is a tragedy. So the next time you laugh at AI-generated clips, think of this—think of what it's costing the world.



NO SURPRISE

A decade hence, PCNHS still on top

REY MARK CAPUTOL

Panabo City National High School cruised to its straight unbeaten overall championship as it put together its valiant campaign in over a decade.

Bulls once again proved too much to handle after claiming the top of the table in the 2025 edition with an array of 119 gold medals on top of 65 silvers and 43 bronzes at the end of the competition on Saturday.

Contributing to that haul was the 2024 Palarong Pambansa qualifier Aaron Petagara who delivered a stunning golden medal sweep in the archery after capturing seven golds in his collection to hail as the most bemedalled athlete of the event.

Panabo Private Schools relegated to second overall after clinching 49 golds, 56 silvers and 53 bronze while A.O Floirendo National High School came third with 40 golds, 40 silvers, and 28 bronzes to cap off the campaign.

South Secondary Schools Defenders (8-26-23), Panabo City Senior High School Unicorns (8-15-25), and North Secondary Schools Thunder Hawks (5 – 11- 24) rounded up to top six with their brilliant performances. Gold medalists from different schools will look to continue their prowess and gear up for the upcoming much-anticipated 2026 Davao Regional Athletic Association Meet.

PHOTO CREDIT: Panabo City Information Office

standpoint

Empowering Athletes Through Collective Efforts

REY MARK CAPUTOL

Imagine pouring your heart and soul into your passion, striving to reach new heights, but every step forward feels like a struggle against the tide—your community cannot afford to offer you enough materials or equipment that could help you thrive.

Numerous Filipino students excel not only in academic fields, but also in local, national, and even in international sporting events. However, it is a glaring reality that some athletes struggled to exhibit and hone their skills due to the lack of facilities and equipment, most especially in public schools.

The sporting spirit of Filipinos have always been known globally, such as Carlos Yulo, who took home back to back gold medal in Paris Olympics, bringing pride and glory to the motherland. Countless students have always dreamt of it, but how can this dream come true if we do not have adequate facilities to shape their potentials?

An increasing number of students were given fewer opportunities in public schools to excel in their sporting fields. This problem remained pervasive in Panabo City

National High School, where some athletes and even coaches constantly enduring this matter while silently dreaming to acquire the supports they deserve.

This issue is also added by the fact that some aspiring student-athletes had little-to-no time enhancing their abilities for the reason that some educators are not knowledgeable enough to guide their athletes.

It can be a huge waste of unlimited potential of a young dreamer could possibly become an Olympic medalist.

Thus, this rampant and circulating problem needs to be resolved and addressed by the school, community and educational sector through collective efforts. Those erstwhile athletes, families, individuals and the government can always pitch in and donate to public schools in order to encourage young

aspiring athletes to pursue their passion towards excellence. Insufficiency is a hard pill to swallow. Some schools are not capable of sustaining the needs of their students in terms of extracurricular activities, including sporting fields.

However, with small yet beneficial efforts of various sectors of the society can somehow alleviate the rising issue about budgets.

Hard work, perseverance and dedication will always take a dreamer to his/her deserving place, but without concrete support of the community, it would surely be challenging to achieve the pinnacle of triumph. Through strengthening collective efforts, athletes will definitely be given many opportunities to exhibit their skills even in international stage. After all, if we do not establish a united community or nation, who else will do?



RING DOMINANCE. Angusto overwhelms Belleza with relentless punches, securing a decisive win in the Juniors 44-46kg Pin Weight Category Boxing Tournament. BY: Reymark Caputol

Crowd favorite Angusto clobbers Belleza in boxing tournament

REY MARK CAPUTOL

PANABO CITY — Hometown bet John Carl Angusto proved to be the king of his own jungle.

Leaning on home-court advantage, Panabo City National High School pugilist retained his lethal form to steamroll visitor Emnae Belleza of Tagum City NHS in the Juniors 44-46kg Pin Weight Category Boxing Tournament on November 21 at the PCNHS Twin Building. The red-clad fighter did not disappoint the crowd as he wasted no time in ruling the mats with a flurry of head and body punches right from the get-go to send Tagumenyos reeling and cap off the win.

“Kada punch nako especially kung taas ang kalaban, taason pod nako ang pag-punch and careful lang sa pag-atake,” Angusto remarked.

Eying to douse Belleza's early aggressiveness, the Panaboan seemed

to have found a way to solve the puzzle, countering with a string of precise body shots that caught Tagum off-guard in the opening bell.

Angusto then sneaked in his favored lefty hooks and employed defensive tactics neutralizing the opponent's long-range punches to ensure a decisive first round triumph.

That was pretty much the same story in the second frame where the red-clad fighter continued to capitalize on Belleza's sloppy defense and uncork multiple hooks sending the blue-clad to another mishap.

Once Angusto got rolling, the opposition had no answer. Fueled by electrifying crowd, Panaboan pride remained on the driver's seat, unloading a barrage

of attacks that pinned the Tagumenyos to the corner, ultimately topping off the victory.

Meanwhile, the much taller tagumenyo could hardly find ways to withstand Panabo's attacking mode despite of his crisp punches and pesky defense. Furthermore, the bleeding pursued for Belleza in the third frame after yielding to the Angusto's quick responses.

“Nag kulang gyud ko ditoa sa follow-up. Kapag malipong na ang kalaban, pasagdaan ra nako,” Belleza said. Both athletes will look to improve their performances and continue to gear up for their future battles.



SILVER SURGE

Pulmones zooms to Batang Pinoy Criterium race silver in style

REY MARK CAPUTOL

Despite a slippery terrain, the Panaboan pride sprinter Myron Cedric Pulmones hardly flinched as he delivered a dazzling performance to claim the silver medal in the 2025 Batang Pinoy Boys 12-13 Criterium category held in General Santos City on October 26.

Pulmones, a Grade 8 journalism student, kicked into high gear midway through the lap and sprinted away down the homestretch, finishing strong with a 27:51 clocking behind Cebu's Jhanzoe Canas, who registered 26:49 outing for the gold.

Dylan Saab of South Cotabato relegated to bronze, submitting the same time as the silver medalist, but ultimately finishing third in a tight contest.

The 13-year-old Pulmones beamed with pride over his breakthrough performance, securing not only a silver medal but also another appearance for next year's Batang Pinoy competition.

"Na happy ko Kay Wala ko nag expect nga makuha Nako ang silver medal ug secured nami next year nga batang pinoy which is sa Bacolod unya lahi na akong category dulaan which is 14-15 Kay 12-13 man karon nga year," Pulmones

expressed.

Pulmones maintained a steady rhythm with the pack right from the start before revving up his engine going through the midway of the race.

However, it was Canas who made a decisive move, as the Cebuano cut loose from the peloton on the homestretch and stormed a more than one-minute lead for the golden finish.

The Panaboan held his nerve tight down the final stretch and crossed the line in a thrilling dead heat with Saab, but a desperate late bike throw of the Cotabato representative allowed Pulmones to secure the second place.

Pulmones will look to further showcase his prowess as he will be vying once again in the next year's Batang Pinoy competition.



27min. 51sec

INSIDE STORIES



P.13

BULL-DOZER

Fiery PCNHS cruises past MCPI to book DavRAA ticket

REY MARK CAPUTOL

PCNHS VS MCPI

SET 1 **25-21**

SET 2 **25-13**

SET 3 **25-21**



VICTORY IN THREE.
PCNHS asserts dominance at the net, dispatching MCPI in straight sets to secure a DavRAA place
-Chloe Mae Tadle

PANABO CITY—There is simply no stopping the Bulls for now.

Panabo City National High School retained its lethal form to pull the rug from under Maryknoll College of Panabo in a one-sided 25-21, 25-13, 25-21 triumph to capture the Men's Volleyball championship crown on Saturday during the 2025 City-wide Athletic Association Meet at the Salvacion Elementary School.

The Bulls came out waxing hot from the get-go with a barrage of scattered attacks while banking on their well-built defense to gnaw the Blue Eagles and punch their ticket in the Davao Region Athletic Association Meet.

Team Captain Kaizo Ayso stepped up big on the defensive side while Zaijun Saberon and Ibasco combined forces with penetrating offense all throughout the match to ultimately

cap off the win.

Fueling the team's performance, head coach Kenneth Licaros challenged his team to play beyond city-level output and aim for victory in the upcoming regional battle.

"Akong ginatanom sa ilang huna-huna, we are not preparing to win the city meet, we are preparing to win DavRAA; If ilang mindset is to win the city meet, ang ilang effort kay gamay ra," Licaros remarked.

This win marked the team's third straight championship since 2022.

Both squads went on a neck-and-neck battle as they exchanged markers early in the first set resulting to a 10-10 deadlock.

However, the Eagles found their rhythm as they capitalized on error-prone Bulls with a 7-1 spurt to break the game wide open and secure a 17-11 lead midway of the game.

The public school team never looked back from there and stormed another 5-1 run to secure a decisive first set victory.

Riding on the momentum, the Bulls continued to establish the same story in the second frame where they quickly zoomed away and fashioned a 9-0 spread that forced Maryknollians in catch-up side.

The squad in black imposed their will and banked on Eagles' defensive lapses for another 6-2 lead enough to seize a commanding 25-13 cushion.

It was all Nationalians from that point on.

Leaning on their strategic showing, the Bulls remained on the driver's seat and held off multiple surges from Maryknollians as team captain Ayso fired the finishing touch to put the game in bed.

Meanwhile, Maryknollians' catch-up output went down the drain after succumbing to Bulls' offensive prowess, settling them for silver finish.

With the win, Panabo City NHS volleyball team will continue to gear up for the upcoming much-anticipated 2026 Regionals battle.

PHOTO CREDIT:
Panabo City Information Office

PEDAL POWER. Myron Pulmones bolts his way to silver finish in the Batang Pinoy 12-13 Criterium category.
-Reymark Caputol